

neither civil nor **POLITIC**

It was a stage dominated by performers ranging from a prime ministerial hopeful to a thwarted chief minister

PRIME MINISTERIAL STAKES



SIPRA DAS

THE PLOT THICKENS: L.K. Advani (left) with Manmohan Singh

There is something about L.K. Advani that never fails to provoke the usually mild-mannered Manmohan Singh. Advani has taken to referring to Manmohan as "India's weakest prime minister ever" and accused him of "ineptitude and arrogance". Hardly surprising then, when BJP announced Advani's name as its prime ministerial candidate-in-waiting it was Manmohan who led the Congress attack, mocking this as a desperate move to claim the title before he was ousted by Narendra Modi from BJP's leadership. Manmohan also told Advani that he will have to wait a very long time before he becomes the prime minister.

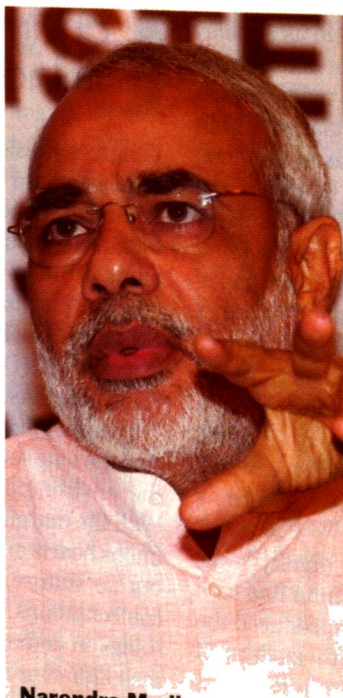


Sonia Gandhi

SIPRA DAS

MERCHANTS OF SLOGANS

Did Sonia really target Modi personally in her "merchant of death" speech? The Congress could not make up its mind but Modi got the message loud and clear. In an instant, he raised the stakes in a state election by turning it into a Sonia vs Modi battle. He had already been mocking the "Rome Rajya" in the Congress vs the Ram Rajya of BJP. After her comments, he sharpened his attack on "Soniaben". As a political analyst quipped, "it was a fight between the merchants of death and the merchants of Venice."



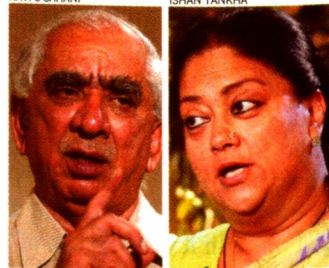
Narendra Modi

YASBANT NEGI

DESERT STORM

RAVI S SAHANI

ISHAN TANKHA



Jaswant

Vasundhara

This was no storm in a teacup. In fact, even Jaswant Singh's wife joined the fray when she criticised posters showing Vasundhara as a goddess. The chief minister retorted claiming she should not be underestimated just because she wears bangles. Later Jaswant hosted her rivals for lunch and opium.